

The Temple of Shar

8 September 2026

The old tree in Greenrest budded overnight, and by breakfast the whole town was standing around it calling it a miracle. Then a shopkeeper looked at a painting the party had carried out of a hag's parlour and put a name to the man in it — the name Thomas has been hunting for half a year. They rode north to a temple of the Lady of Loss, where a priest was waiting with that man chained to a wall, a piece of the broken heart around his neck, and an offer. Thomas took the prisoner. He did not take the offer. He came out of that temple with a black sword, a third of a heart, and one fewer name than he went in with.

The Dream of the Summer

The night in the inn was quiet — Gren claimed a human-sized bed entirely for himself and laid caltrops at the door against the possibility of Pip — and then all four of them dreamed the same dream, together, for the second time.

- **The hillside, again.** High summer this time, and the valley below in full bloom. Under the great tree stood a blonde woman, and coming up the hill to meet her, a raven-haired man. She loves him — the kind of knowing that only happens in dreams — and the valley blooms harder every time he smiles at her.
- **The seasons turn and only one of them ages.** Summer to spring to autumn, never quite winter, and each time he climbs that hill there is more silver in his hair. She does not change at all.
- **The offer, at the end.** The two of them sitting beneath the tree, his silver head against her shoulder, her hand in his hair, neither of them smiling. They both know what is coming and only one of them can do anything about it. She turns to him and says: *stay. I will make it summer for you forever. Be as I am. Never end.*
- **Jetten dreamed it in trance**, and his moonstone went green again as he slipped under.

Jetten's fae blood turned up the old stories the next morning with perfect clarity: dryads are fae who loved mortals and were punished into trees for it. This was not the dreamer's grief. This was the bargain she offered.

A Tree in Bud, and a Mayor Out of Patience

Nobody in the common room was eating. Ambrose came straight over with the news — the square first, breakfast after. Hundreds of buds, fat and green, and one blossom already open on a tree that nobody living has ever seen bloom. Gren, who had attuned to *the Tideheart* overnight, walked it toward the square and felt the thing beat harder the closer it came. Two hearts recovered, and the tree answering both.

Mayor Oswin Applewhite bought them eggs and then asked the question he had clearly been holding: *what is it you keep bringing back to our home?* It went badly. Gren pressed on the dryad and on a goddess who has plainly forsaken this town's priest; Thomas laid out the corpse-trade; Oswin counted the free rooms and the unpaid-for breakfasts and stood up to leave, and he was not performing his anger. It was Morgash who caught him — not with a secret, but with the plain shape of the truth: beyond the town's edge, where Greenrest does not go, there have been evil things, and all this party has done is clean them out, and the tree has been getting better while they did it. Oswin sat back down and thanked him for finally being honest. He has taken his last dose of the tonic for a while, by agreement, to see what he dreams.

The Name in the Ledger

Selma the apothecary does not like change and intends to answer the first dreams in living memory by brewing a stronger potion. She also handed back Sera's longbow rather than sell it, and Morgash took it.

Then Mother Wend looked at the gilt-framed portrait — the one thing the party had pointedly kept out of the sale — and knew him at once. The green waistcoat. The gold signet ring he liked to show off. She went to her own ledgers and came back with a name: **Renlow Veck**. A pleasant man. Paid on time. Came through every couple of months, took the Fen Trail out with sealed boxes and came back without them, and was last seen half a year ago heading home to Daggerford. She had always assumed the boxes were apples.

Gren read the brass plate aloud — the gift, the gratitude, the joke about never biting the hand that feeds you — and Wend checked her dates against the hags' cipher. Every deposit lands within a day or two of one of his trips through her town. Morgash leaned on her hard enough to be certain of it: if Veck ever walks back into Greenrest, she delays him and sends word to the mayor and the constable.

The Iris

A day's march north, a quiet camp, no dream, and then the forest went silent around a great ring of pale stone in an old meadow. Four hooded faces watch inward from the compass points. The floor is a disc cut in curved petals that meet at a single point, like a shutter over an eye, closed. There is no door and nobody came out.

Intelligence was gathered from a squirrel named Pudgy, who had heard of Gren and was thrilled about it. People in purple robes, in and out, scary-looking, keep to themselves; they live down the stairs; they mostly come out at night. Pudgy was paid in nuts. Morgash read the steps and found no dust and no cobwebs on them.

The Offer

The priest came up to meet them and was not remotely surprised. He gave Thomas his own name and his dead wife's in the same breath, said his order had followed the work for years, and then made a case that was uncomfortably well constructed: Thomas's power does not come down from Lathander, it comes up out of the oath, and the oath is built from what was taken from him. Shar is the Lady of Loss. He has lost, and he turned it into strength. That is rare. The order did not want a supplicant. It wanted him to lead. A Justiciar.

He confirmed he held a piece of the broken heart. And then, pleasantly, as though offering a drink: he had Renlow Veck downstairs, and Veck was a gift.

The Cell

A bare-chested man bolted to the rock by both wrists, in ragged trousers, with a gold signet ring still on his right hand. He began apologising before anyone spoke to him. Thomas put a booming voice behind the question and Veck gave the whole thing up without being pressed: it started with selling names — widows, people with nobody left to come asking after them. It was only ever money. Then a careful scribe in a ledger office started pulling at the threads and would not stop, so he went to that scribe's house to frighten him, and it went wrong, and he said out loud that he knew whose family he had killed.

The priest, from the doorway, encouraging: *that's it. Become vengeance.*

Morgash got both arms around him and held. Jetten worked the other side — there is more to this than meets the eye, the priest wants something in return, and this will not bring them back. For about ten seconds the hold was good. Then the *Gauntlets of Ogre Power* did what they were made to do, and Thomas stood over the chained man with the point of First Light at his chest, and put it in.

Midnight

The blade did not flare. That is the first thing anyone noticed — that it should have and it didn't. The warmth went out of the steel. The vision of the dawn-god's paladin that had come with the sword simply wasn't there any more; the god stepped back and away like a man leaving a room. The rose-gold ran to ink. The blade drank the candlelight and gave nothing back, went black, and named itself aloud. **Midnight**. Purple fire crackles along the edge of it now.

Then the Lady took her fee, and she took it out of his memory. His first name is gone. He reached for it and there was nothing there, and it did not trouble him, and that is the part that should trouble everyone else. He is **Justiciar Invictus** now. Later in the evening someone used the old name near him and he genuinely did not know who they meant.

The priest pulled his robe down to show the heart hanging against his chest and named the actual price. Never join the four. Never wake the sleeping archfey. Whole, the heart is four true resurrections — a wife, children, and the Lady's own magic to stretch it further — and all Shar wants in exchange is that a demigoddess, an old friend of both the Earthmother and the Moonmaiden, stays in her grief forever. As long as she suffers, the Lady is content.

Invictus turned it down. *Then I cannot give you the heart*, said the priest. So they took it.

Down the Stairs

Invictus opened on Harrow Vane alone. *Shield Master* put the high priest flat on the stone and Midnight came down twice into him before he could stand. It was not enough. Harrow asked whether they had really thought it would be that easy, spoke a *Word of Recall*, and was simply elsewhere. *I'll see you downstairs*.

Morgash took the ring finger off the corpse in the cell, signet and all, to carry home to Greenrest as proof. Upstairs, three Sharrans rose and did not know what to do about a man holding a black sword. Invictus told them to kneel and kiss his hand, and one of them did. *My Dark Justiciar. I am here to serve*. They would not turn on their high priest, but they stood aside.

The floor below was seven of them — zealots with halberds, enforcers, acolytes. An acolyte opened with *Spirit Guardians*, dark shapes wheeling around her, and Jetten shot the concentration out of her with the first arrow of the round; his *Hunter's Mark* and *Dreadful Strike* rode it in together. Morgash killed her outright a heartbeat later,

the maul finding her so cleanly that *Great Weapon Master* handed him another swing for free.

Then it got hard. The enforcers went for the ranger and kept putting him on the floor with *Trip Attack*, and a halberd finally put Jetten down entirely — Invictus's *Lay on Hands* got him back on his feet. An acolyte caught Morgash in *Hold Person* and he stood there paralysed while the fight moved past him. And twice Gren dropped a *Fireball* into the middle of the room with *Careful Spell* laid over it, so the blast folded around every friend in the radius and burned only Sharrans. The second one killed two of them where they stood. Invictus cut down a zealot; Jetten shot the last one; and with Harrow's voice echoing and mocking down the corridor, a *Prayer of Healing* bought the party a whole short rest before they went to find him.

Harrow Vane

Oh, Thomas. Invictus. Whatever your name is anymore. You could have been so much more. But now I have to kill you.

He fought like something that had never had to hurry. Twice every round, in the gaps between other people's turns, a burst of necrotic force went out of him — and every single one of them went at Morgash. An *Unholy Word* rolled over three of them at once, stunned Jetten where he stood and tore the *Bane* off Invictus's tongue. When a shield bash finally put him on the floor he spent something deep and old to simply refuse it and stand back up.

Morgash carried the worst of it and gave it back. The pike found a seam and drove clean through — *Great Weapon Master* again, then a miss that *Precision Attack* turned into a hit by the width of a fingernail, then an *Action Surge* to do it all a second time. Invictus laid a *Divine Smite* on top of a Midnight strike. Gren woke his *Innate Sorcery* and put fire into him. And when Harrow called down a pillar of flame that dropped Morgash where he stood, the orc's *Relentless Endurance* refused it and he came back up out of the fire still holding the maul.

Jetten ended it. Goldthorn came round at the waist. The high priest's legs stayed standing; the rest of him did not.

Spoils & Progress

- **The Duskheart** — the third piece of the broken heart, taken off Harrow Vane's chest. Jetten carries and is attuned to it: advantage on Wisdom saves, and *Modify Memory*, which is about as Sharran a gift as exists.

- **Midnight** — what First Light became. Black steel, necrotic edge. Carried by Justiciar Invictus, at a price already paid.
- **Vesper Staff** — Gren. Black ash, smoked-glass lens, and a considerable boost to both spell attacks and spell save DCs.
- **Robe of Protection** — Morgash, who dropped the Periapt of Wound Closure to make room for it.
- **Sera's longbow** — Morgash, returned as a gift by Selma rather than sold.
- **The hag hoard, liquidated** — teas, silks, the whalebone combs, both oil paintings, all three ornate teacups, the tapestry, the silver service and the wired dragon bones. Roughly fifteen hundred gold into the party purse, and six potions of healing straight back out of it.
- **The temple, stripped** — a palm-worn gold disc off a reading-room plinth, the violet stone from the veiled woman's basin, gold tesserae chiselled out of two defaced suns, a rack of the alchemist's cave-bloom draught, five jet-and-silver holy symbols, a folio of star charts with no sun anywhere on them, and a bolt of deep purple sanctuary velvet.
- **A finger and a signet ring**, in Morgash's pack, bound for Greenrest.
- **Level six**, all four of them, before next session.

Quotable Quotes

"Thomas Invictus of Daggerford. Anne's husband."

— Harrow Vane, opening a negotiation the way one opens a wound.

"It was money. It was only ever money."

— Renlow Veck, explaining.

"He is no friend. He deserves to die — but not here, not now."

— Morgash the Gravemaker, with both arms around a paladin.

"Out of honour, I have to kill this guy. End of story."

— Thomas A. Invictus, for the last time under that name.

"I am Midnight."

— the sword, introducing itself.

"I don't know what you're talking about. My name's always been Justiciar."

— Justiciar Invictus, entirely sincerely.

"I am Gren, slayer of Longshadow. Bow before my magnificence and tell me what you know of this temple."

— Gren Greenmantle, to a squirrel, who complied.

Deeds of the Day

- **The Considerate Incendiary** — Gren Greenmantle, for two fireballs that filled a room and did not singe a single friend standing in it.
- **Finest Diplomacy in Faerûn** — Morgash the Gravemaker, who talked a furious mayor back into his chair before breakfast and then held a paladin off a murder before dinner.
- **The Arrow That Mattered** — Jetten Elisedil, for shooting the concentration out of a priestess on the same round she cast, and for the cut that ended the high priest.
- **Most Comprehensive Career Change** — Justiciar Invictus, who entered the temple a paladin of the dawn and left it with a black sword, a new title, and one name fewer.
- **Best Informant, Non-Humanoid Division** — Pudgy, for full and frank disclosure regarding the purple robes, in exchange for one nut.

Next time: Three pieces of the heart are in the party's hands and the fourth is still out there somewhere green. Greenrest does not yet know that the man in the painting is dead, that one of them killed him in chains, or what he was carrying out along the Fen Trail all those months. And the Lady of Loss has been told to her priest's face that they intend to make the heart whole.

Recorded at the table — transcribed & chronicled by the party scribe.